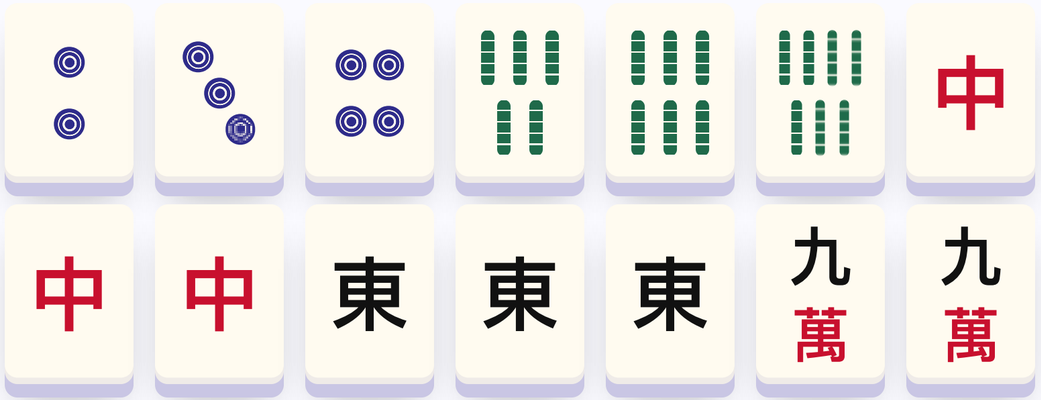
Hong Kong Mahjong, the complete guide

Tiles, turns, claiming, winning and scoring

Hong Kong rules, for first-time players

Four players, 144 tiles, win with 14



A WINNING HAND: 4 SETS + 1 PAIR

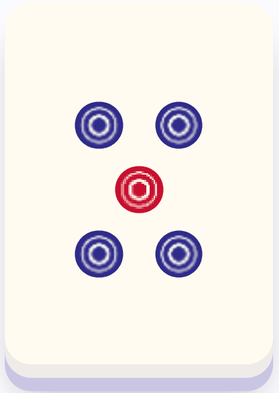
- Four players around a square table
- 144 tiles in total
- Goal: form four sets and a pair
- Each set is a chow, pung or kong

The tiles

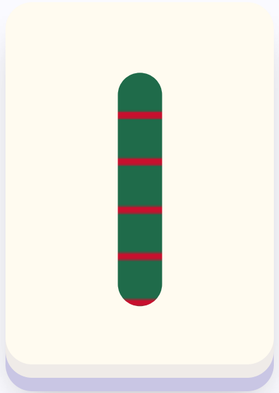
Explore suits, honours, and bonuses

Dots, bamboo, characters

- Dots (tung) numbered 1-9
- Bamboo (sok) numbered 1-9, on real sets 1-bamboo is often a bird
- Characters (maan) numbered 1-9
- Four copies of each rank



5 DOTS



1 BAMBOO



9 CHARACTERS

Winds and dragons

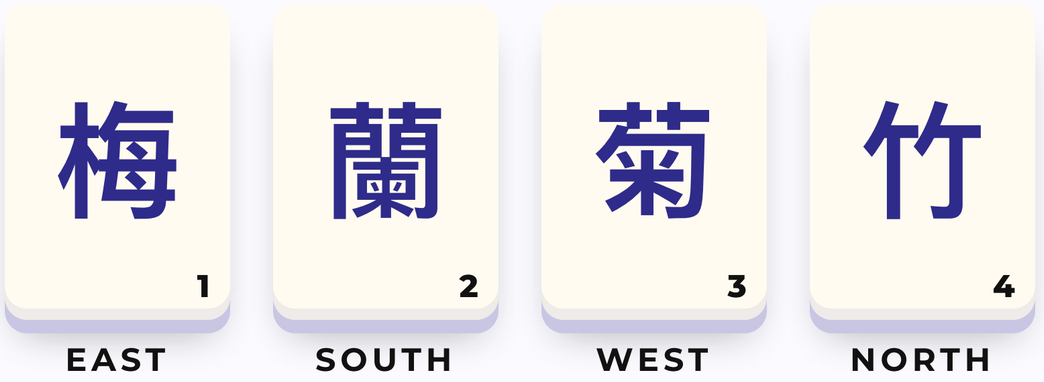
- Winds: East, South, West, North
- Dragons: Red, Green, White
- Four copies each
- Used for specific hands and scoring



Flowers and seasons

- Eight bonus tiles total
- Flowers 1 to 4 match East, South, West, North
- Seasons 1 to 4 match the same seats
- Set aside when drawn, replace from wall

FLOWERS



SEASONS

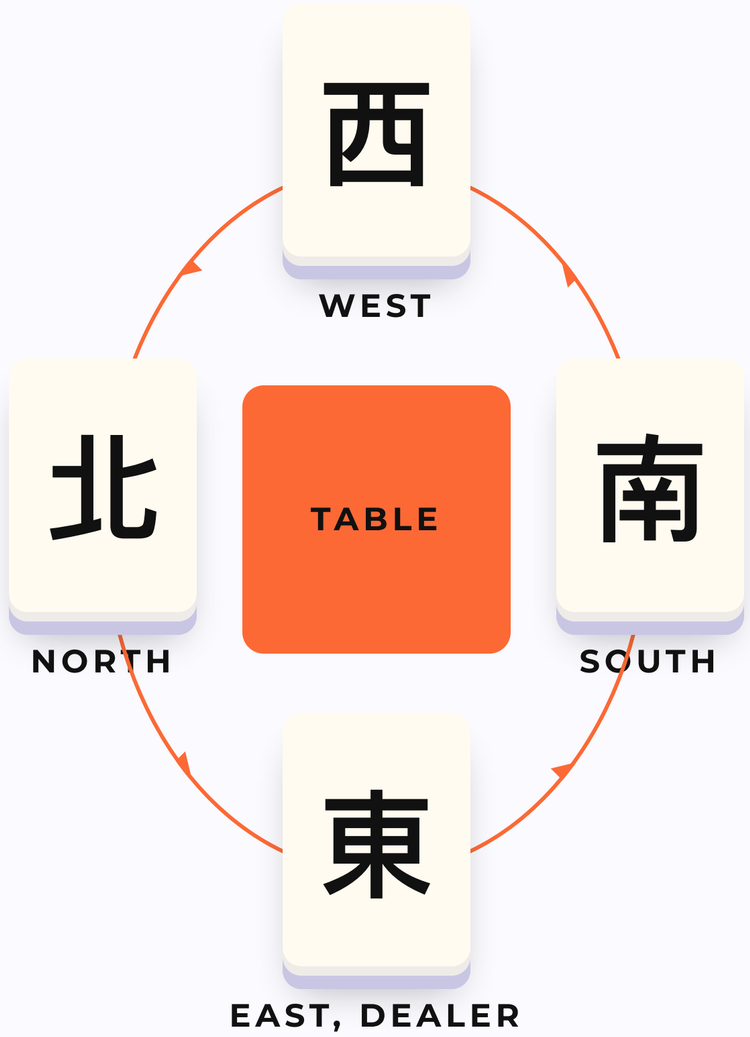


Game flow overview

From seating to the final discard, the round moves step by step.

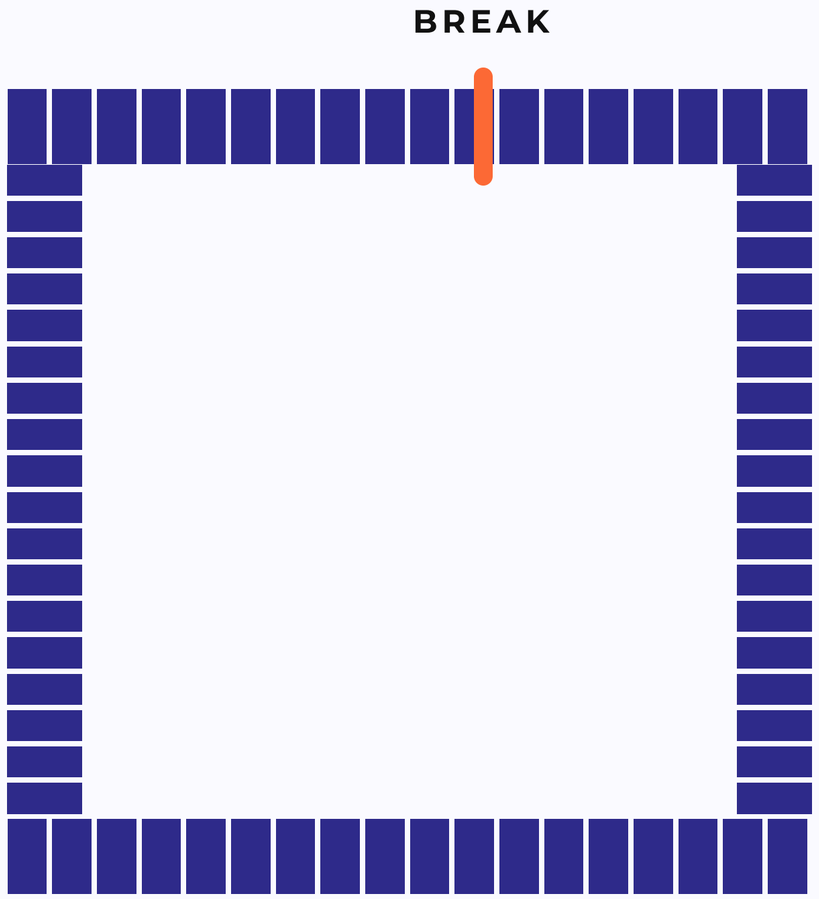
Seats, dealer, anticlockwise turns

- Four seats, each a wind
- Dealer sits East
- Play moves anticlockwise: East → South → West → North
- Dealer starts with 14 tiles and discards first



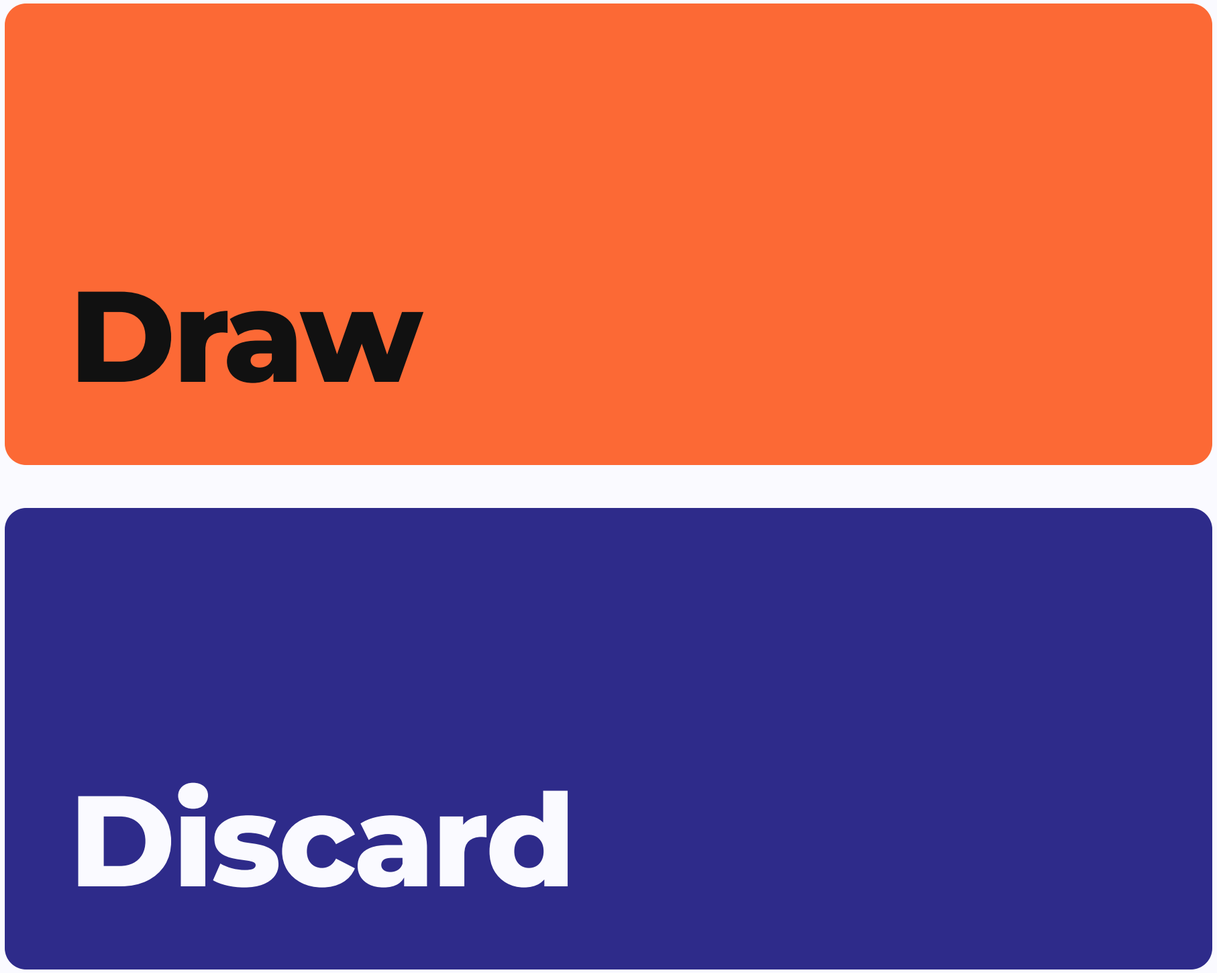
Wall construction and initial deal

- Build four walls of 18 stacks (2 tiles each)
- Roll dice to pick break point
- Deal 13 tiles each; dealer gets 14th then discards
- Keep your hand hidden from the others



Draw a tile, then discard

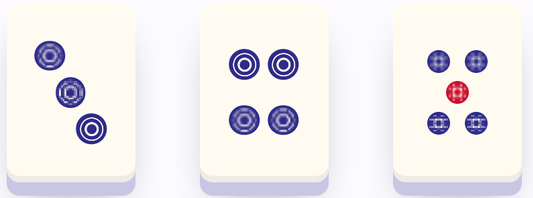
- Draw from the wall or claim the last discard
- Check whether your hand now wins
- Discard one tile face up
- Continue anticlockwise



Chow, pung, kong claims

- Chow: three consecutive in same suit, only from left neighbour
- Pung: three identical, from any player
- Kong: four identical, exposed or concealed
- Priority: win > pung/kong > chow when multiple claim

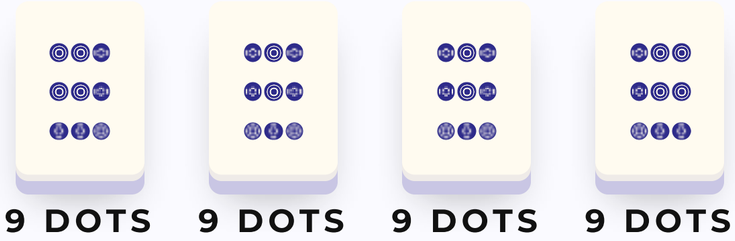
CHOW



PUNG



KONG



What makes a hand win

Four sets plus a pair, meeting the minimum fan.

Worked example: 4 sets + 1 pair

CHOW,
2-3-4 DOTS

CHOW,
5-6-7 BAMBOO

PUNG,
RED DRAGON

KONG,
EAST WIND

PAIR,
9 CHARACTERS



15 tiles on the table: the kong uses 4, but still counts as one set

3 fan: dragon pung 1, kong of your seat wind (you sit East) 1, no flowers 1

Everyday fan values

Self-drawn (zi mo)	1
Concealed hand, won on a discard (mun cin cing)	1
No flowers or seasons	1
Own flower/season matching seat	1 each
Pung of dragons	1 each
Pung of seat wind or prevailing wind	1 each
All chows (ping wu)	1

A kong counts as a pung for scoring. Values vary by house.

High-value and limit hands

All pungs (deoi deoi wu)	Mixed one suit (wan jat sik)	Pure one suit (cing jat sik)	Small three dragons (siu saam jyun)	Big three dragons (da saam jyun)
3	3	7	5	8

Limit hands (e.g., Thirteen Orphans) up to 10-13 fan

Payment doubles with each fan

Rounds, dealer stay, draws

- Four rounds: East, South, West, North
- Dealer wins: dealer stays East (lin zong)
- Dealer loses: the deal passes to South
- Wall runs out, no winner: a draw (lau guk)



Starter strategy tips

01 Choose fast cheap win or build one suit

02 Keep pairs and close tiles, like 3-4 or 6-8

03 Discard lone honours and terminals early

04 Watch opponents' discards for safe tiles

05 Count fan before claiming to meet minimum

Etiquette & house-rule checklist

- [ ] Announce claim loudly (上, 碰, 槓, 食糊)
- [ ] Shuffle face-down (洗牌 sai paai)
- [ ] Confirm bonus-tile handling and draw-on-kong rule
- [ ] Never touch wall or others' tiles out of turn
- [ ] Agree on fan minimum and payment method
- [ ] Decide payment: discarder pays all or everyone pays